

Artemis

Some children—people don't recall the exact number—playing around the sanctuary found some rope, and having tied it round the neck of the statue pretended that Artemis was being hanged. The Caphyans, when they discovered what the children had done, stoned them to death. A sickness then fell upon the wives of those who had done these things and they gave premature birth to stillborn babies. For this reason the Pythia decreed that they bury the children who had been stoned and offer sacrifice to them every year, since they had been unjustly killed. To this day the Caphyans perform this ritual in accordance with the oracle and call Artemis . . . the Hanged Goddess.

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 8.23.6–7



THE HOMERIC HYMN TO ARTEMIS (27) draws the essential features of her character and appearance: beautiful virgin of the hunt, armed with bow and arrows.

I sing about Artemis of the golden arrows, chaste virgin of the noisy hunt, who delights in her shafts and strikes down the stag, the very own sister of Apollo of the golden sword. She ranges over shady hills and windy heights, rejoicing in the chase as she draws her bow, made all of silver, and shoots her shafts of woe. The peaks of the lofty mountains tremble, the dark woods echo terribly to the shrieks of wild beasts, and both the earth and fish-filled sea are shaken. But she with dauntless heart looks everywhere to wreak destruction on the brood of animals. But when the huntress, who delights in her arrows, has had her fill of pleasure and cheered her heart, she unstrings her curved bow and makes her way to the great house of her dear brother, Phoebus Apollo, in the rich land of Delphi, where she supervises the lovely dances of the Muses and the Graces. After she has hung up her unstrung bow and arrows, she takes first place and, exquisitely attired, leads the dance. And they join in a heavenly choir to sing how

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Leto of the beautiful ankles bore two children who are by far the best of the immortals in sagacious thought and action. (1–20)

Hail, children of Zeus and Leto of the lovely hair; yet I shall remember you and another song too.

The shorter *Homeric Hymn to Artemis* (9) dwells upon the closeness of Artemis and Apollo and their cult places in Asia Minor. There was a temple of Artemis where the river Meles flows near Smyrna, and Claros was the site of a temple and oracle of Apollo.

Sing, O Muse about Artemis, the virgin who delights in arrows, sister of Apollo, the far-shooter, and nursed together with him. She waters her horses at the river Meles, thick with rushes, and swiftly drives her chariot, made all of gold, through Smyrna, to Claros, rich in vines; here Apollo of the silver bow sits and waits for the goddess who shoots from afar and delights in her arrows. (1–6)

So hail to you, Artemis, with my song and at the same time to all the other goddesses as well; yet I begin to sing about you first of all and, after I have made my beginning from you, I shall turn to another hymn.



The Birth of Artemis and Apollo

The goddess **Leto** mated with Zeus and bore the twin deities Artemis and Apollo. The story of Apollo's birth on the island of Delos is recounted in Chapter 11 in the version given by the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo*.¹ Traditionally, Artemis is born first and is able to help with the delivery of her brother, Apollo, thus performing one of her primary functions as a goddess of childbirth early in her career (a role she shares with Hera and Eileithyia, as we have seen). Her birth on Mt. Cynthus in Delos gave her the cult title of **Cynthia**. According to Ovid, after the birth of Artemis and Apollo, Leto was forced by the anger of Hera to wander carrying her two babies. She came to Lycia, where the Lycians refused to allow her to drink water from a marsh. In anger, she changed them into frogs to live their lives in the marsh whose water they had refused to give her.

On other occasions, too, Artemis is closely linked with Apollo, both appearing as vehement and haughty agents of destruction with their shafts of doom. Sudden death (particularly of the young) was often attributed to these two deities, Artemis striking down the girls, Apollo the boys.

Artemis the Huntress. Roman copy in marble of a Greek bronze of the late fourth century B.C.; height 78 in. Artemis appears both as huntress, taking an arrow from her quiver, and as protectress of animals, as she grasps the leaping stag. Her short skirt, sandals, and loose clothing are appropriate for the activity of the hunt. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

Niobe and Her Children

One of the most famous exploits of Artemis and Apollo concerns Niobe and her children, told at length by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 6. 148–315).

The women of Thebes bestowed great honor upon Leto and her twin children, crowning their heads with laurel and offering up incense and prayers in obedience to an injunction by the goddess herself. Niobe, however, was enraged by the whole proceedings and rashly boasted that she was more deserving of tribute than Leto. After all she was rich, beautiful, and the queen of Thebes.² Besides, Leto had borne only two children, whereas Niobe was the mother of seven sons and seven daughters. Indeed, Niobe was so confident in the abundance of her blessings that she felt she could afford to lose some of them without serious consequences.

Leto was enraged at such hubris and complained bitterly to Artemis and Apollo. Together the two deities swiftly glided down to the palace of Thebes to avenge the insulted honor of their mother. Apollo struck down all the sons of Niobe with his deadly and unerring arrows, and Artemis in turn killed all her daughters. Just as Artemis was about to shoot the last child, Niobe in desperation shielded the girl and pleaded that this one, her youngest, be spared. While she was uttering this prayer, she was turned to stone, and a whirlwind whisked her away to her homeland, Phrygia, where she was placed on a mountaintop. Tears continue to trickle down from her marble face as she wastes away.³

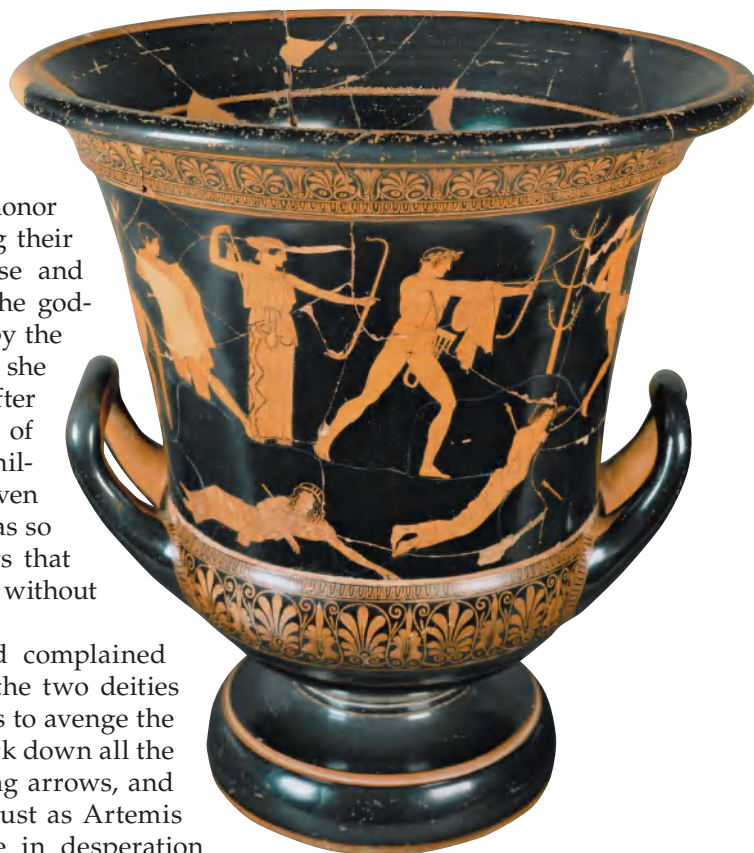
Actaeon

Several stories illustrate the hallowed purity of the goddess Artemis. A famous one concerns Actaeon,⁴ an ardent hunter who lost his way and by accident (or was it fate?) had the misfortune to see Artemis (Diana in Ovid's version) naked (*Metamorphoses* 3. 138–255):

Actaeon was the first to tinge with grief the happiness of his grandfather, Cadmus. A stag's horns grew on his head, and his hounds feasted on their master's flesh. Yet, if you look closely, you will find that his guilt was misfortune, not a crime; what crime indeed lies in an innocent mistake? (138–142)

There was a mountain on which had fallen the blood of beasts of many kinds. It was midday, when shadows are at their shortest and the Sun is midway in his course. Young Actaeon calmly called his fellow huntsmen as they tracked the game through the depths of the pathless forest: "My friends, our nets and spears are wet with the blood of our prey; we have had luck enough today! Dawn's saffron-wheeled chariot will bring another day tomorrow and then we

Death of the Children of Niobe. Attic red-figure krater by the Niobid painter, ca. 460 B.C.; height 21¼ in. The stark cruelty of the gods is shown by the cool detachment of Artemis as she reaches for an arrow out of her quiver, and equally by the restrained energy of Apollo. The Niobids are painted in a rocky landscape (only formally sketched) and disposed on different levels, an unusual technique for vase painters of the time, and possibly related to contemporary wall painting: contrast the contemporary *Death of Actaeon*, on page 227. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)



will renew the chase. The Sun now stands midway 'twixt east and west and with his hot rays parches the earth. Stop now the hunt, and take in the knotted nets!" His men obeyed and halted from their labors. (143–154)

There was a vale called Gargaphië, sacred to the huntress Diana; clothed with a dense growth of pine and pointed cypress, it had at its far end a woodland cave which no human hand had shaped. . . . on the right from a murmuring spring issued a stream of clearest water, and around the pool was a grassy bank. Here would the woodland goddess rest when weary from the hunt and bathe her virgin body in the clear water. That day she came there and to one of her nymphs handed her hunting spear, her quiver and bow, and the arrows that were left. Upon another's waiting arms she cast her cloak, and two more took off her sandals. . . . Other nymphs⁵ fetched water and poured it from ample urns. And while Diana thus was being bathed, as she had been many times before, Actaeon, Cadmus' grandson, his labors left unfinished, came to the grotto uncertain of his way and wandering through the unfamiliar wood; so fate carried him along. Into the dripping cave he went, and the nymphs, when they saw a man, beat their breasts and filled the forest with their screams. (155–180)

They surrounded Diana and shielded her with their bodies, but the goddess was taller than they and her head overtopped them all. Just as the clouds are tinged with color when struck by the rays of the setting sun, or like the reddening Dawn, Diana's face flushed when she was spied naked. Surrounded by her nymphs she turned and looked back; wishing that her arrows were at hand, she used what weapons she could and flung water over the young man's face and hair with these words, foretelling his coming doom: "Now you may tell how you saw me naked—if you can tell!" And with this threat she made the horns of a long-lived stag⁶ rise on his head where the water had struck him; his neck grew long and his ears pointed, his hands turned to hooves, his arms to legs, and his body she clothed with a spotted deerskin. And she made him timid; Autonoë's valiant son ran away in fear, and as he ran wondered at his speed. He saw his horned head reflected in a pool and tried to say "Alas"—but no words would come. He sobbed; that at least was a sound he uttered, and tears flowed down his new-changed face. (180–203)

Only his mind remained unchanged. What should he do? Go home to the royal palace? Or hide in the woods? Shame prevented him from the one action, fear from the other. While he stood undecided, his hounds saw him. Blackfoot and clever Tracker first raised the hue and cry with their baying, the latter a Cretan hound, the former of Spartan pedigree. Then the rest of the pack rushed up, swifter than the wind, whose names it would take too long to give.⁷ Eager for the prey, they hunt him over rocks and cliffs, by rough tracks and trackless ways, through terrain rocky and inaccessible. He fled, by ways where he had often been the pursuer; he fled, pursued by his own hounds! He longed to cry out "I am Actaeon; obey your master!" He longed—but could utter no words; and the heavens echoed to the baying hounds. First Blackie gored his back; then Hunter followed, while Hill-hound gripped Actaeon's shoulder with his teeth. These three had been slower to join the chase but had outstripped the pack along mountain shortcuts; while they held back their master, the pack came up and all sank their teeth into his body. His whole body was torn by the hounds; he groaned, a sound which was not human nor yet such as a stag could make. (203–239)

The hills he knew so well echoed with his screams; falling on his knees, like a man in prayer, he dumbly looked at them in entreaty, for he had no human arms to stretch out to them. But the huntsmen, ignorant of the truth, urge

on the pack with their usual cries; they look around for Actaeon and loudly call his name as if he were not there. At the sound of his name he lifts his head; they think it a pity that he is not there, too slow to see the sight of the stag at bay. He could indeed wish he were not there! But he is; he could wish to be the spectator, not the victim, of his hounds' cruel jaws. Completely encircling him, with jaws biting deep, they tear in fact their master's flesh when he seems to be a stag. Only when his life has ebbed out through innumerable wounds, was it said that the vengeance of the huntress Diana was satisfied. (239–252)

Opinions varied about the deed. Some thought the goddess had been more cruel than just; others approved and said that her severity was worthy of her virgin chastity. Each view had good reasons to support it.



Closer Look

Callisto and Arcas

The same insistence on purity and chastity and the same vehemence against defilement of any sort appear in the story of Callisto, one of the followers of Artemis (or Diana, as Ovid tells it; *Metamorphoses* 2. 409–507):

As Jupiter journeyed back and forth to Arcadia, he saw the Arcadian girl Callisto, and the fires of love were kindled in his bones. She did not care to draw out the unworked wool or to change her hair's style. She would pin her dress with a brooch, keep her hair in place with a white ribbon; with a smooth spear in her hand or a bow, she marched in Diana's troops. No other girl who trod the Arcadian hills was dearer to the goddess—but no one's power can last for long! (409–416)

High in the heaven rode the Sun beyond the middle of his course, when Callisto came to a wood that no one throughout the years had touched. Here she took off the quiver from her shoulder and unstrung the pliant bow; she lay upon the grassy ground, her head resting upon the painted quiver. Jupiter saw her, tired and unprotected. "My wife," said he, "will never discover this affair, and if she does—well, the prize is worth her anger." So he disguised himself to look like Diana and said: "Dear girl, my follower, upon which mountain did you hunt?" Callisto sprang up from the turf. "Hail, goddess," said she, "greater in my opinion than Jupiter—and let him hear my words!" (417–429)

Jupiter smiled as he heard this, glad that Diana was preferred to himself; he kissed the girl, more warmly than a maiden should. He cut short Callisto's tale of the forest hunt with an embrace, and as he forced his advances showed her who he really was. Callisto fought against him with all a woman's strength—Juno's anger would have been lessened could she have seen her—but who is weaker than a girl, and who can overcome Jupiter? He won; to the heavens he flies and she hates the wood that knows her shame; as she fled from it, she almost forgot to take her quiver and arrows and the bow that she had hung up. (429–440)

The Death of Actaeon.

Athenian red-figure krater by the Pan painter, ca. 460 B.C.; height 14½ in. Artemis shoots Actaeon, who falls in agony as his hounds tear him. Actaeon is shown in fully human form, and the small size of the hounds compels the viewer to focus on the human figure and his divine antagonist. The scene of the consequences of chastity violated is made the more poignant by the reverse of this vase (on p. 326), which shows the lustful god Pan pursuing a goatherd. (Photograph © 2010 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)

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Audio

Diana saw her as she moved with her followers along the heights of Maenalus, flushed with pride at the beasts she had killed, and called her. Callisto hid, afraid at first that Jupiter in disguise was calling her. But as she saw the nymphs and goddess go on together she knew it was no trick and joined the band. Poor Callisto! How hard it is not to show one's guilt in one's face! She could hardly lift her eyes from the ground; no longer did she stay close to Diana's side nor be the first of all her followers. In silence she blushed and showed her shame; if Diana had not been a maiden, she could have known Callisto's guilt by a thousand signs. They say that the nymphs realized it. (441–452) 30

The horned moon was waxing for the ninth time when Diana, weary from the chase and tired by the sun, her brother's flaming heat, reached a cool wood; here flowed a babbling stream, gliding over its smooth and sandy bed. She praised the place; she dipped her feet into the water and it pleased her. "No man is here to spy on us," she cried: "let us bathe naked in the stream!" Callisto blushed; the others took off their clothes; she alone held back. And as she delayed, they stripped her, and then her naked body and her guilt were plain to see. She stood confused, trying to hide her belly with her hands; but Diana cried: "Be off from here! Do not defile these sacred waters!" and expelled her from her band. (453–465) 40

Long before, Juno had known the truth and put off revenge until the time was ripe. She saw no cause to wait now; Callisto's son, Arcas (his very name caused Juno pain), had been born, and when Juno's cruel gaze fell on him she cried: "So only this was left, you whore; for you to be pregnant and by this birth make known the wrong I suffer and my husband's shameful act! But I will have my revenge! I will take away the beauty that pleases you so much and gives my husband, you flirt, such pleasure." (466–475) 50

And as she spoke she seized Callisto's hair and threw her to the ground. Callisto spread her arms in suppliant prayer; her arms began to bristle with black hair, her hands to be bent with fingers turning to curved claws; she used her hands as feet and the face that once delighted Jupiter grew ugly with grinning jaws. Her power of speech was lost, with no prayers or entreaties could she win pity, and a hoarse and frightening growl was her only utterance. (476–484)

Yet Callisto's human mind remained even when she had become a bear; with never-ceasing moans she made known her suffering; lifting what once had been her hands to heaven, she felt Jupiter's ingratitude, although she could not with words accuse him. Poor thing! How often was she afraid to sleep in the solitary forest, before her former home; how often did she roam in the lands that once were hers! How often was she pursued over the rocky hills by the baying hounds; how often did the huntress run in fear from the hunters! Often she hid herself (forgetting what she was) and though a bear, shrank from the sight of bears; wolves scared her, although her father Lycaon had become one. (485–495) 60

One day Arcas, now nearly fifteen years old and ignorant of his parentage, was out hunting; as he picked a likely covert and crisscrossed the forests of Mt. Erymanthus with knotted nets, he came upon his mother. She saw him and stood still, like one who sees a familiar face. He ran away, afraid of the beast who never took her gaze from him (for he knew not what she was); he was on the point of driving a spear through her body, eager as she was to come close to him. Then almighty Jupiter prevented him; he averted Arcas' crime against his mother and took them both on the wings of the wind to heaven and there made them neighboring stars. (496–507) 70

Callisto became the **Great Bear** (Arctus, or **Ursa Major**); **Arcas** the Bear Warden (Arctophylax, or Arcturus, or Boötes) or the Little Bear (**Ursa Minor**). Ursa Major was also known as Hamaxa (the Wain). The story of Callisto is typical of myths that provide the etiology of individual stars or constellations. These stories (most of which belong to late antiquity) are told about various figures in mythology, and several of them cluster about Artemis herself.

Orion

One such story concerns Orion, a composite figure about whom many tales are related with multiple and intricate variations.⁸ He is traditionally a mighty and amorous hunter and often associated with the island of Chios and its king, Oenopion (the name means “wine-face”; Chios was and still is famous for its wines). The many versions play upon the following themes. Orion woos the daughter of Oenopion, Merope; he becomes drunk and is blinded by the king, but he regains his sight through the rays of the sun-god, Helios. While he is clearing the island of wild beasts as a favor for Oenopion, he encounters Artemis and tries to rape her. In her anger, the goddess produces a scorpion out of the earth that stings Orion to death.⁹ Both can be seen in the heavens. Some say that Orion pursued the **Pleiades** (daughters of the Titan Atlas and Pleione, an Oceanid), and they were all transformed into constellations; with Orion was his dog, **Sirius**, who became the **Dog Star**.

Arethusa

The river-god Alpheus loved the nymph Arethusa, a follower of Artemis or, according to the sixth-century poetess Telesilla, Artemis herself. As he pursued Arethusa along the river bank, she prayed to Artemis, who covered her with a cloud; as the god watched the cloud, both it and the nymph melted into a stream for which Artemis cleft the earth. Flowing underground (where it was united with the waters of Alpheus) and under the sea, it emerged at Syracuse in Sicily, where it is still called by the same name, the fountain Arethusa.

Origins of Artemis

The origins of Artemis are obscure. Although she is predominantly a virgin goddess, certain aspects of her character suggest that originally she may have had connections with fertility.¹⁰ Artemis’ interest in childbirth and in the young of both humans and animals seems to betray concerns that are not entirely virginal. Her close association with animals is portrayed on the handle of the François vase. At Ephesus in Asia Minor, a statue of Artemis depicts her in a robe of animal heads, which in its upper part exposes what appears to be (but may not be) a ring of multiple breasts (see p. 232). We should remember, too, that Artemis became a goddess of the moon in classical times. As in the case of other goddesses worshiped by women (e.g., Hera), this link with the moon may be associated with the lunar cycle and women’s menstrual period. Thus, the evident



Artemis as Mistress of Animals (*Potnia Theron*). One of the handles of the François Vase by the potter Ergotimos and the painter Kleitias, ca. 575 B.C.; height of vase 30 in. (see p. 511). Artemis is shown in profile, winged and wearing the peplos, an archaic robe folded over the shoulders, belted, and descending to the feet. She is holding a panther and a stag. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

Artemis Brauronia

The Brauronia, a festival held every four years, was celebrated with a procession from Athens to Brauron. The importance of the cult of Artemis at Brauron (on the eastern coast of Attica) is attested by the archaeological finds, which include a temple of Artemis, a stoa with several dining rooms, which was used to display small marble statues, and reliefs dedicated by parents in gratitude for successful childbirth. Many other types of offering have been found (e.g., ornaments, mirrors, pottery, jewelry). According to Euripides (*Iphigenia in Tauris* 1461–1467), Iphigenia was the first priestess and is buried there.

Lysistrata tells us (Aristophanes, *Lysistrata* 644–655): “I was a bear at the Brauronia and wore and shed the yellow robe” (*kroko-tos*). This rite (called the Arcteia) performed at Brauron was also referred to as playing the bear, serving as a bear for Artemis, or dedicating oneself to Artemis. Significant evidence for what is meant are the *krateriskoi*, small cheap bowls of mediocre quality, found also at other shrines of Artemis in Attica (e.g., Munychia in the Piraeus), depicting scenes of girls singing and dancing, holding torches or running in races, dressed in rags or naked, with an altar or a palm tree, or a part of a bear.

Were these girls’ initiation or passage rites, a release of their wildness to be restrained by the societal demands of adulthood, marriage, and motherhood, with characteristics of a mystery cult involving secret ceremonies forbidden to the male? The myth behind the ritual explained that once a bear in the region of Brauron, sacred to Artemis, scratched a young girl (*parthenos*) while she played with it. Her brothers killed the bear and a plague befell the Athenians. As payment for the slain bear and release from the plague, Athenians were required to have their maidens do the bear ritual. They also ordained that no woman could marry until she had played the bear for the goddess.

All girls five to ten years of age were required to become “bears” before marriage. They served for a year as attendants in the sanctuary, and together, dressed in yellow robes, they would perform the sacrifice of a goat (a substitute sacrifice for a virgin) to placate the deadly anger of Artemis and ward off, for their community and for themselves, plague, famine, and death, especially in childbirth.¹¹

duality in Artemis’ character and interests definitely links her with the archetypal concept of the virgin/mother.¹²

Artemis, Selene, and Hecate

As a moon-goddess, Artemis is sometimes closely identified with Selene and Hecate. Hecate is clearly a fertility deity with definite chthonian characteristics. She can make the earth produce in plenty, and her home is in the depths of the Underworld. She is a descendant of the Titans and in fact a cousin of Artemis.¹³ Hecate is a goddess of roads in general and crossroads in particular, the latter being considered the center of ghostly activities, particularly in the dead of night. Thus, the goddess developed a terrifying aspect; triple-faced statues depicted the three manifestations of her multiple character as a deity of the moon: Selene in heaven, Artemis on earth, and Hecate in the realm of Hades. Offerings of food (known as **Hecate’s suppers**) were left to placate her, for she was terrible both in

her powers and in her person—a veritable Fury, armed with a scourge and blazing torch and accompanied by terrifying hounds. Her skill in the arts of black magic made her the patron deity of sorceresses (like Medea) and witches. How different is the usual depiction of Artemis, young, vigorous, wholesome, and beautiful! In the costume of the huntress, she is ready for the chase, armed with her bow and arrow; an animal often appears by her side, and crescent moonlike horns rest on her head; the torch she holds burns bright with the light of birth, life, and fertility. Whatever the roots of her fertility connections, the dominant conception of Artemis is that of the virgin huntress. She becomes, as it were, the goddess of nature itself, not always in terms of its teeming procreation, but instead often reflecting its cool, pristine, and virginal aspects. As a moon-goddess too (despite the overtones of fecundity), she can appear as a symbol, cold, white, and chaste.

Artemis Versus Aphrodite: Euripides' *Hippolytus*

In her role as a goddess of chastity, Artemis provides a ready foil for Aphrodite's voluptuous sensuality. In this view, Artemis becomes at one and the same time a negative force, representing the utter rejection of love and also a positive compulsion toward purity and asceticism. No one has rendered the psychological and physiological implications of this contrast in more human and meaningful terms than the poet Euripides in his tragedy *Hippolytus*.

As the play begins, Aphrodite is enraged; her power is great and universal, yet she is vehemently spurned by **Hippolytus**, who will have absolutely nothing to do with her. The young man must certainly pay for this hubris, and the goddess uses his stepmother, **Phaedra**, to make certain that he will. Phaedra is the second wife of **Theseus**, the father of Hippolytus (for the saga of Theseus, see Chapter 23). Aphrodite impels the unfortunate Phaedra to fall desperately in love with her stepson. Phaedra's nurse wrests the fatal secret of her guilty love from her sick and distraught mistress and makes the tragic mistake of taking it upon herself to inform the unsuspecting Hippolytus, who is horrified. The thought of physical love for any woman is for him traumatic enough; a sexual relationship with the wife of his father would be an abomination.

In her disgrace, Phaedra commits suicide; but first she leaves a note that falsely incriminates Hippolytus, whose death is brought about by the curse of his enraged father, Theseus, a heroic extrovert who has never really understood the piety of his son. Artemis appears to her beloved follower Hippolytus as he lies dying. She promises him, in return for a lifetime of devotion that has brought about his martyrdom, that she will get even by wreaking vengeance on some favorite of Aphrodite, and she will establish a cult in honor of Hippolytus as well—virgin maidens will pay tribute to him by dedicating their shorn tresses and lamenting his fate by their tears and their songs.¹⁴ Theseus realizes his error too late; he must suffer the consequences of his rash and hasty judgment against Hippolytus; but in the end father and son find understanding and reconciliation.

At the close of the play, we are left with a fascinating chain of enigmas in the Euripidean manner, as the two opposing goddesses—both as real characters and psychological forces—manipulate the action. Is Hippolytus a saint or a foolish and obstinate prig? Has he destroyed himself through the dangerous, if not impossible, rejection of the physical? Are human beings at the mercy of ruthless and irrational compulsions inherent in their very nature, which they

deify as ruthless and vindictive women? Certainly, the two goddesses play upon the basic character of the human protagonists. Aphrodite uses the essentially sensual Phaedra, and Artemis responds to the purity of Hippolytus' vision. Each of us is created in the image of a personal and controlling god, or each creates one's own special deity, according to his or her individual nature and character.

Obviously, then, a study of Euripides' *Hippolytus* becomes vital for understanding the nature of both Artemis and Aphrodite. For those who want to study Euripides' play in more detail, the Additional Reading at the end of this chapter offers crucial excerpts with commentary, including the entire final episode in which Artemis herself appears and reveals her essential characteristics.

This is one of Euripides' best plays because of its masterful construction and its deceptively transparent simplicity, endlessly revealing intricate subtlety of thought and complexity of characterization. In the context of this and the previous chapter, Euripides' profound and critical scrutiny of the antithetical Artemis and Aphrodite and their worship should be primary.

The Misogyny of Hippolytus

In Euripides' play, after Hippolytus learns from the nurse of Phaedra's desire for him, he bursts out in a tirade against women as vile and evil (p. 237). This reaction has received a great deal of attention and interpretation, particularly today, because of its misogyny. Hippolytus' hatred of women is to be understood, but not necessarily condoned, in the context of his character and the play. This chaste man has suffered the most traumatic shock of his young life. Sex with any woman for him is impossible. The sudden realization of the lust of Phaedra, the wife of his beloved father, strikes him as an abomination. His feelings are in some ways similar to the misogyny of another holy man, John the Baptist, in his outbursts against Salome and her mother, Herodias. Not the least of his psychological problems are his own illegitimacy and the character of his mother, a vehement and chaste Amazon, who succumbed to his father Theseus.

Yet some see in Hippolytus' outcry against women the expression of views generally held in Greek society, particularly in fifth-century Athens, as though somehow Hippolytus himself were a typical ancient Greek male. It is abundantly clear from the play that he is anything but that. Aphrodite herself punishes him for his aberration, and his father hates him for his



Artemis of Ephesus. Alabaster and bronze, mid-second century A.D. The Ephesian Artemis continues the ancient tradition of the goddess as protectress of nature—seen in the rows of animal heads on her robe, sleeves, breastplate, and head-disk—and revives her original connection with fertility, shown by the multiple breastlike objects (whose identity is much debated). The turreted *polos* (crown) and the figure of Nike (Victory) on her breastplate are symbols of her role as protectress of the city of Ephesus. This Artemis is the “Diana of the Ephesians” at the center of the riot described in the Bible (Acts 19:23–41). (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

religious fanaticism and cannot believe his virginal protestations; Theseus hastily convinces himself that Hippolytus raped Phaedra because he never could believe that his boy does not like women. Theseus is the archetype of the traditional, extrovert father who loves his wife and is disappointed by his son who has turned out to be an introvert, different from him in almost every way. If one were to pick an average Athenian (a dangerous, if not foolish, game to play), it would be Theseus.

Misandry, Artemis, and the Amazons

Misandry, hatred of men, rather than misogyny, is a more immediate theme in connection with Artemis, where it manifests itself in the close religious bonds of her group, which excludes the male, as made evident in the stories of Actaeon and Callisto. In this connection, the Amazons are relevant, important figures not only in the legends of Theseus, but also in those of Heracles and the Trojan War; the Amazons developed a society not unlike that of Artemis the huntress, which excluded men. The Amazons, however, were devoted to the pursuit of battle and were determined to become invincible warriors. Their *arete* (excellence) was to be the same and in no way different from that of a male.

Lesbian Themes

Lesbianism is a latent motif in stories about the strong bond of affection among Artemis and her band of female followers. The atmosphere is virginal and the relationships pure, although the success of Jupiter with Callisto, when he takes the form of her beloved virgin goddess Diana, is fraught with Freudian overtones and makes one wonder. Athena, another virgin goddess, has close female companions. In Chapter 8, we learned the tragic story of her relationship with Pallas, and she was also closely linked to the nymph Chariclo, who became the mother of Tiresias. Because of the avowed purity of these two virgin goddesses, it seems appropriate that Aphrodite (and not Artemis or Athena) should preside over more sensual female relationships.

The society and mores of the warlike Amazons may also be subjected to lesbian interpretations, if one so desires.

Additional Reading: Euripides' *Hippolytus*

Euripides' *Hippolytus* takes place in front of the palace in Troezen, a city linked to Athens and the hero Theseus. In a typically Euripidean prologue (cf. the opening of the *Bacchae* in Chapter 13), the mighty goddess Aphrodite proclaims the universality of her power and establishes the action of the play. She is outraged because the young and virginal hunter Hippolytus slights her and bestows all his love and attention upon Artemis; she explains how she will exact vengeance (1–28):

APHRODITE: I am called Cypris, a mighty and renowned goddess both in heaven and among mortals. Everyone who looks upon the light of the sun throughout the whole world (from the eastern boundary of the Black Sea to



the western limit of the straits of Gibraltar) is at my mercy; I reward those who celebrate my power, but I destroy all who with arrogant pride oppose me. For gods, just like mortals, enjoy receiving honor. I will show you the truth of these words directly. (1–9)

Hippolytus, the illegitimate son whom the Amazon woman bore to Theseus, this Hippolytus, brought up by the good Pittheus, is the only citizen of this place Troezen who declares that I am the worst of deities. He renounces sex and rejects marriage, and reveres Artemis, the sister of Apollo and daughter of Zeus, believing her the greatest of deities. Throughout the green woods, he rides the land of wild animals with his swift dogs, always intimate with the virgin goddess and experiencing a greater than mortal relationship. I am not envious. Why should I be? But for his sins against me I will take vengeance upon Hippolytus this very day. I have long since made great progress; I need exert little more effort. For once, when Hippolytus came from the house of Pittheus to Pandion's city of Athens to witness the sacraments of the holy mysteries, Phaedra looked upon him; and she the noble wife of his father was struck to the heart by a terrible desire, in accordance with my plans. (10–28) 10 20

These last lines beautifully and succinctly epitomize the tragedy, with their swift series of powerful images. In one fatal moment, sensuous and mature Phaedra glimpses the beautiful, young, chaste, and religious Hippolytus and is overwhelmed by her lust (the Greek word used is *eros*), which is hopeless and impossible and can only lead to catastrophe.

Aphrodite tells us that Theseus is absent from Troezen on a self-imposed exile and that Phaedra, tortured by her guilt, is determined to die without revealing her love for her stepson. She goes on to outline the course of the drama. Although Phaedra, before leaving Athens for Troezen, had built a shrine to Aphrodite on the Acropolis, she must die so that vengeance may be exacted against Hippolytus; Aphrodite is more concerned about punishing her enemy Hippolytus than she is about the suffering and death of the unfortunate Phaedra. As Hippolytus enters with a throng of servants singing the praises of Artemis, “most beautiful of the Olympian deities,” Aphrodite withdraws with the dire pronouncement that the joyous youth does not realize that this is the last day of his life.

The prayer with which Euripides introduces us to Hippolytus defines the essential nature of the young man and of Artemis; he stands before a statue of the goddess offering her a diadem of flowers (73–87):

HIPPOLYTUS: For you, my mistress, I bring this garland which I have fashioned of flowers plucked from a virgin meadow untouched by iron implements, where no shepherd has ever presumed to graze his flock—indeed a virgin field which bees frequent in spring. Purity waters it like a river stream for those who have as their lot the knowledge of virtue in everything, not through teaching but by their very nature. These are the ones for whom it is right to pluck these flowers, but those who are evil are forbidden. My dear lady, accept from my holy hand this garland to crown your golden hair. I alone of mortals have this privilege: I am with you and converse with you, for I hear your voice, although I do not see your face. As I have begun life in your grace, may I so keep it to the end. (73–87) 10

One of the servants warns Hippolytus of the consequences of his hubristic refusal to pay homage to a statue of Aphrodite. Hippolytus avows that since he

is pure, he must keep his distance from a goddess who is worshiped in the night, and he bids her a haughty goodbye.

A chorus of women from Troezen expresses concern about Phaedra's mysterious illness and conjectures about its nature. When Phaedra, weak, pale, and wasted, makes her entrance, accompanied by her faithful Nurse, they realize the seriousness of her predicament. In the following scene, only with great difficulty can the Nurse wrest from her distraught mistress the guilty secret that she is in love with her stepson Hippolytus. An anguished Phaedra, whose ravings had been fraught with ambiguous and sexual innuendo, at last explains to the women of Troezen. She begins with some general thoughts (deeply pondered during her tortured, sleepless nights) about how lives of human beings have been destroyed. People are not ruined because they have no moral sense but because they fail to carry out what they know to be right due to inertia or weak submission to temptations and less honorable action. She goes on to explain how her conclusions apply directly to her own behavior and suffering (391–430):

PHAEDRA: I will tell you the course of my resolves. When *eros* struck me, I thought about how I might best endure the wound. And so I began in this way: to be silent and to hide my affliction. (For one's tongue is not at all trustworthy; it knows how to advise others in a quandary but gets for oneself a multitude of evils.) My second plan was to endure this madness steadfastly, mastering it by self-control. (391–399)

But when I was unable to overcome Cypris by these means, it seemed best to me to die, the most effective of all resolutions—as no one will deny. The good and noble things that I do should be witnessed by all but not my bad and shameful actions. I knew that both my sick passion and its fulfillment were disreputable, and besides, I have learned well the lesson that being a woman and a wife I was open to disgrace. May she die in damnation, that woman, a pollution to us all, who first defiled her marriage bed with other men. This wickedness began in the houses of the nobility to become a defilement on all the female sex. For whenever shameful acts seem right to the aristocrats, most certainly they will seem good to the lower classes. (400–412)

I also hate women who say that they are chaste but in secret dare to commit unholy acts. O Lady Cypris, mistress of the sea, how in the world can such women look into the faces of their husbands? How can they help but tremble in the dark, their accomplice, in fear that the walls of the house will utter a sound? (413–418)

My friends, I must die for this simple reason: that I may never be found guilty of bringing shame upon my husband and the children whom I bore. Instead may they live and flourish in the renowned city of Athens, free men, open in speech and their good reputation unsullied by their mother. For man is enslaved, even if he is bold of heart, whenever he is conscious of the sins of a mother or a father. (419–425)

They say that to win in life's contest, one needs only this: a good and just character. But the base among mortals are exposed, sooner or later, when Time holds a mirror before them, as before a young girl. Among such as these may I never be discovered. (426–430)

Thus the noble Phaedra reveals her character and her motivation. The Nurse, upon first learning of Phaedra's love for Hippolytus, was shocked and horrified.



Audio

Now, however, in response to her mistress, she offers assurances that Phaedra's experience is nothing unusual. She is the victim of the goddess of love, like many others. Not only mortals but even deities succumb to illicit passions. Phaedra must bear up. The pragmatic Nurse ends her sophistic arguments by claiming that she will find some cure. She is deliberately ambiguous about the precise nature of this cure so that she can win Phaedra's confidence, hinting at some potion or magic that must be employed. She dismisses Phaedra's fear that she will reveal her love for Hippolytus—but this is exactly the cure that she has resolved upon, with the preliminary precaution of exacting from the young man an oath of silence.

From Hippolytus' angry shouts that come from the palace, poor Phaedra learns that her Nurse (in a loving but misguided attempt to help) has indeed approached Hippolytus. She overhears Hippolytus brutally denouncing the Nurse, calling her a procurer of evils, in betrayal of her master's marriage-bed. Phaedra, believing that she is now ruined, confides to the Chorus that she is resolved to die. We do not have Euripides' stage directions. Some would have Phaedra exit at this point, but the drama is intensified and her subsequent actions are more comprehensible if she remains, compelled to witness the entire following scene. Hippolytus bursts forth from the palace followed by the Nurse (601–668):

HIPPOLYTUS: O mother earth and vast reaches of the sun, What unspeakable words have I listened to! (601)

NURSE: Be quiet, my boy, before someone hears you shouting.

HIPPOLYTUS: I have heard such dreadful things that it is impossible for me to be silent.

NURSE: Please, by your strong right hand. (605)

HIPPOLYTUS: Keep your hands off me! Don't touch my cloak!

NURSE: I beseech you, by your knees. Don't ruin me.

HIPPOLYTUS: What do you mean? Didn't you claim that there was nothing wrong in what you said?

NURSE: What I said was by no means intended for all to hear.

HIPPOLYTUS: Good words spread among many become even better. (610)

NURSE: My child, do not be untrue to your oath, in any way.

HIPPOLYTUS: My tongue swore but my mind is under no oath.

NURSE: My boy, what will you do? Ruin those near and dear to you?

HIPPOLYTUS: I spit upon them! No evil person is near and dear to me.

NURSE: Be forgiving. To err is human, my son. (615)

HIPPOLYTUS: O Zeus, why did you bring them into the light of this world—women—an ingrained and deceitful evil for mankind? If you wanted to propagate the race, it is not from women that you should have ordained our birth. Instead, men should be able to buy children in your temples, each making a payment of bronze, iron, or gold, appropriate to his means, and live free in homes without females. (616–624) 20

Hippolytus rages on to show how obvious it is that a woman is a great evil. A father settles on a dowry to be rid of his very own daughter because she is pernicious. A husband takes the woman into his house and enjoys adorning this worthless and ruinous creature with expensive jewelry and fine clothes, little by little squandering his estate, poor fool.

The husband with a wife who is a nonentity has it easiest. Although not without harm, she is kept from folly by her lack of intelligence. "A clever woman, I loathe. May I never have in my house a woman who is more clever than she should be," Hippolytus exclaims, "for Cypris breeds more villainy in the clever ones." Also, a woman should not have access to a servant but instead only wild and dumb animals, so they may not be able to speak to anyone or receive an answer in return. These last admonitions bring Hippolytus back from his wild generalizations to his present trauma, which provoked them. He erroneously thinks that the Nurse has been sent by a wily and evil Phaedra on her abominable mission, and he goes on to denounce her (651–668).

Thus it is that you, wicked creature, have come to make a deal with me to debauch the sacred bed of my father. I will pour running water into my ears to wash out the pollution of your words. How could I be a sinner, I who feel defiled by just listening to such a vile proposition? Woman, understand this clearly, my piety is your salvation. If I had not been caught off guard and bound by my oath to the gods, I would never keep myself from telling this filthy business to my father. For the time being, as long as Theseus is away from Troezen, I will absent myself from the palace and keep my mouth shut. But I will return when my father does and watch how you face him, both you and your mistress. Having this taste of your effrontery, I will be knowledgeable. (651–663) 10

May you be damned. I will never have my fill of hatred for women, not even if anyone criticizes me for always declaring it. For they all, like you, are evil in one way or another. Either someone should teach them how to be temperate or allow me to trample them down forever. (664–668)

The Greek word translated "to be temperate" is *sophronein*, which has the basic meaning of to show good sense, to exercise self-control and moderation in all things. It is particularly ironic, spoken here by the intemperate and inhumane Hippolytus. The word may in context connote specific restraint, for example, sexual self-control, that is, to be chaste.

The Nurse is overcome with remorse and guilt for the failure of her scheme, but she cannot assuage the fury of Phaedra, whose only recourse now is to end her own life. She confides her decision to the Chorus, whom she has sworn to secrecy (716–721 and 725–731).

PHAEDRA: I have found a remedy for my misfortune so that I will bequeath to my sons a life of good reputation, and profit from what has now befallen me. For I will never bring shame upon my Cretan home, nor will I go and face Theseus with disgraceful actions for the sake of one life. . . . (716–721)

On this day when I have freed myself from life, I will make Cypris happy, the one who destroys me, and I will be defeated by a bitter eros. But after my death, I will become an evil curse for that other person, so that he may understand that he should not exult haughtily over my misfortunes; by sharing in this malady with me, he will learn how to be temperate. (725–731)

Phaedra reaffirms the convictions she revealed earlier. She cannot face either the loss of her reputation or the risk of sully the reputation of Theseus and her sons, jeopardizing their future. Now she has added another motive for her

actions, similar to that of Aphrodite: vengeance against Hippolytus' cruel and arrogant hubris, which she herself has just witnessed, to exacerbate her humiliation and her suffering.

Phaedra echoes Hippolytus' tirade when she promises that he will learn (i.e., she will teach him) how to be temperate (*sophronein*). There is another reminder of Hippolytus and a chilling ambiguity in her earlier assertion: "nor will I go and face Theseus with disgraceful actions for the sake of one life." Does she mean her life or that of Hippolytus?

Phaedra goes into the palace to commit suicide. She hangs herself, and just as she is freed from the noose and her corpse is laid out, Theseus returns. Overcome with grief, he notices a tablet, bearing her seal, dangling from Phaedra's hand. He reads it in horror and cries out for all to hear: "Hippolytus has dared to violate my marriage bed by force, desecrating the holy eye of Zeus." He calls out to his father Poseidon, who has granted Theseus three curses, and asks that with one of them the god kill Hippolytus, who, he prays, may not live out this day. Theseus also pronounces banishment upon his son. Hearing Theseus' cries, a bewildered Hippolytus appears. In the lengthy confrontation between father and son, the following excerpt elucidates the long-standing difficulties in their relationship and the crux of their conflict. To Hippolytus' protestations that he has done nothing wrong, Theseus exclaims (936–980):



Audio

THESEUS: Oh, the human heart, to what lengths will it go? What limit will one set to boldness and audacity? . . . (936–937)

Behold this man, who was begotten by me; he has defiled my bed and stands clearly convicted of being the basest of human beings by the woman who is dead. Look at your father directly, face to face; don't be afraid that your gaze will contaminate me, I am already contaminated. Are you the man who consorts with the gods, as though you were superior to everyone else? Are you, the pure virgin, unsullied by sin? I could never be convinced by these boasts of yours and wrongly believe that the gods are fooled by your hypocrisy. Now that you are caught, go ahead and brag, show off with your vegetarian diet, take Orpheus as your lord, celebrate the mysteries, believing in their many and vacuous writings. I warn everyone to shun men such as these. For they prey upon you with their holy words, while they devise their evil plots. (943–957) 10

She is dead. Do you imagine that this fact will save you? By this, most of all, O villain, you are convicted. For what kind of oath, what testimony could be more powerful than she to win your acquittal? Will you maintain that she hated you and that it is only natural for a bastard to be in conflict with those who are legitimate? If so, you argue that she made a bad and foolish bargain, if she destroyed what is most precious, her own life, out of hostility to you; but will you claim that folly is an attribute of women and not found in men? I know that young men are no more stable than women, whenever Cypris plays havoc in their young hearts; yet because they are male, they are not discredited. And so now—ah, but why do I wage this contest of words with you, when this corpse lies here, the clearest witness against you. Get out of this land, go, an exile, as quickly as possible; and stay away from god-built Athens and the borders of any territory ruled by my spear. (958–975) 20

If I am beaten by you, after these terrible things you have made me suffer, Isthmian Sinis will not bear witness to his defeat at my hands but make it my idle boast, and the Scironian rocks by the sea will refute the fact that I am merciless against those who do evil. (976–980)

Theseus' own boasting about his prowess refers to two of his labors, the killing of the robber Sinis at the Isthmus of Corinth and the brigand Sciron on the cliffs that bear his name. No one would believe his prowess against the wicked if he did not punish Hippolytus.

In his denunciation of Hippolytus, Theseus reveals the long-standing rift that has grown between them. However great his love for Phaedra and the shock of her suicide, how could Theseus so readily accept her accusation of rape if he had any understanding of the nature and character of his son? His suspicions about Hippolytus' avowals of purity, which to him smack of haughty superiority, and his ridicule of mystery religions indicate that Theseus, the hero, has little respect for the beliefs of a son who is so different in temperament. (We cannot help but recall that Phaedra was smitten with desire as she observed the pure Hippolytus participating in the Mysteries. A young and innocent man so unlike his father, her husband!)

Theseus imagines that Hippolytus will argue that Phaedra hated him and that conflict between the two of them was inevitable: he was a bastard, she was a stepmother, and as the wife of Theseus she bore him two legitimate sons, rivals to Hippolytus and heirs to the throne. How much has rejection sullied the relationship between Theseus and Hippolytus? In fact, Hippolytus' fanatical devotion to Artemis and his renunciation of Aphrodite reflect a resentment against his father expressed in his devotion to his real mother, who, as an Amazon, would normally have nothing to do with Aphrodite and heterosexual love, had she not been seduced by Theseus. Later, Hippolytus exclaims (1082–1083): "O my unhappy mother, O my bitter birth, may no one dear to me ever be born a bastard!" At this point in the play, Hippolytus answers his father's accusations as follows (983–1035):

HIPPOLYTUS: Father, your strength and the intensity of your rage are terrifying. Yet, although your arguments seem just, if one examines the case you present closely, it is not just at all. I am not good at making a speech before many—I am better at talking to a few people of my own age. This is how things go—just as those who are inept among a group of the wise speak more persuasively before a crowd. Be this as it may, since misfortune has befallen me, I must not hold my tongue. (983–991)

First of all, I will begin by answering your first accusation by which you sought to destroy me without a word to say in response. You see the sky and this here earth. There is no one under the sun more righteous than I am, even if you say this is not so. First, I know how to pay reverence to the gods and to pick friends 10 who try to do no wrong and whose sense of decency prevents them from demanding wrong or doing wrong to others. I do not belittle or betray these companions, father, but am the same to them, whether they are with me or not. I am innocent of the one charge, of which you now think you have convicted me. To this very moment, my body is chaste. I have never had sex but only heard about it, or seen depictions of it which I do not like to look at because I am a virgin, pure in heart and soul. (991–1006)

Suppose you are not convinced about my chastity. So be it. You must then show in what way I was corrupted. Was her body more beautiful than that of 20 any other woman? Or did I hope to become an heir in your palace, by taking her to bed? If so, I was a fool, completely out of my mind. Will you argue that to be a king is a sweet temptation for a man in his right senses? Not in the least, because all those who love the power of a king have been corrupted. No,

I would like to win first place in the Greek Games but in the city to be second and always to enjoy good fortune with the best people for friends; this allows for achievement, and the absence of danger affords more pleasure than kingship. (1007–1020)

You have all my arguments, except for one thing. If I had a truthful witness like myself to testify to what kind of man I am, and if I were pleading my case while Phaedra were still alive to see and hear me, you would know the guilty ones by a careful scrutiny of the evidence. As it is, now I swear to you by Zeus, god of oaths and by vast earth that I never touched your wife, never wanted to, nor ever even had the thought. May I die without a name or reputation, without a city or a home, wandering the earth as an exile, and after my death, may neither sea nor land accept my corpse, if I have done any wrong. (1021–1031)

Why and through what fear she took her own life, I do not know, since it is not right for me to speak further. She acted virtuously, when she could not be virtuous. I am virtuous but I have not used my virtue well.

Hippolytus' last words present Theseus with a riddle. The message he conveys is that Phaedra, when she could not control her passion (she could not be temperate; the verb *sophronein* is used again), was not virtuous. When she committed suicide to ensure that she would not commit adultery, this virtuous act absolved her of guilt. Hippolytus, however, is virtuous and chaste, but his behavior has led to disaster. Hippolytus does not break his oath and reveal the truth but, from many of his words, a less hot-tempered and more sympathetic Theseus would have suspected that his son knows more than he has revealed. For example, Hippolytus picks friends and associates who in character and behavior are the antithesis of Phaedra.

In the heated exchange that follows, the father banishes his son from the land. Hippolytus leaves driving his four-horsed chariot. A messenger comes to report to Theseus the terrible fate of Hippolytus, brought about by the curse that Theseus had evoked through the god Poseidon. His dramatic speech vividly describes how amidst a terrifying surge of the sea, a huge wave brought forth a monstrous bull, bellowing savagely, which made directly for Hippolytus as he was driving his chariot along the sea coast. The four horses were seized by such a panic that even the experienced Hippolytus was not able to control them. In the

The Death of Hippolytus. Lower register of an Apulian volute-krater (a large vase with elaborate handles) by the Darius painter, ca. 340 B.C. The painter illustrates the opening scene described in the messenger's speech from Euripides' *Hippolytus*. To the right an old retainer runs behind the chariot, with a gesture of horror. Hippolytus, dressed as a charioteer, begins to lose control as the four horses panic at the sight of the bull emerging from the sea. To the left a Fury (not mentioned in the messenger's speech) holds a flaming torch with her right hand, while an animal skin is draped over her left arm. The painter chooses the precise moment at which the disaster begins and, with great economy, reduces the messenger's elaborate description to a vivid prelude to the break-up of the chariot and the mutilation of Hippolytus. In the upper register is an array of six gods, only three of whom (Aphrodite, Artemis, Poseidon) are involved in the tragedy. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



horrible crash that ensued, Hippolytus was caught in the leather reins and brutally dragged along the rocks. Finally, he was cut loose; and Theseus, upon learning that his son is still alive, orders that he be brought to face him once again. At this juncture, Artemis appears, a veritable *deus ex machina*, to set things aright, serving as the counterpart to Aphrodite who had opened the play (1283–1466):

ARTEMIS: I command you, royal son of Aegeus, to listen; for I address you, I, Artemis, the daughter of Leto. Why, Theseus, poor wretch, do you take pleasure in these things? You have murdered your son, persuaded to commit this unholy act by the false accusations of your wife, with no clear evidence. Clear, however, is the ruin you have earned. In shame you should hide yourself in the depths of the earth or escape from this misery by exchanging your life for that of a bird above, since you do not deserve to share in the lives of good men. (1283–1295)

Listen, Theseus, to the extent of your evils. Although I will accomplish nothing, yet I will cause you pain. I have come for this purpose, to disclose the righteous nature of your son so that he may die with a good name and the frenzied passion of your wife or, from another point of view, her nobility. For stung by the goads of the goddess most hateful to all of us whose joy is in chastity, she fell in love with your son. (1296–1303)

She tried to overcome Cypris by reason, but she was ruined unwittingly by the machinations of her Nurse, who revealed her malady to your son sworn to secrecy. He did not give in to her entreaties, as was right, and again, being virtuous, he did not break the bond of his oath, although you wronged him so. Phaedra, terrified that she would be exposed, wrote a false letter and destroyed your son by her lies, but nevertheless she convinced you to believe them. (1304–1312)

THESEUS: Woe is me!

ARTEMIS: Do my words sting you? Yet be quiet and listen to the rest so that you may lament all the more. Didn't you know that the three curses you got from your father were bound to be fulfilled? You are a most base man to use one of them against your own son, when you could have used it against any of your enemies. The god of the sea, your father and kindly disposed toward you, fulfilled your curse; he had to, since he had promised. Yet both in his eyes and in mine you appear base, you who did not wait either for proof or the guidance of prophets; you did not put the accusation to the test nor allow a lengthy time for scrutiny but, more quickly than you should have, you hurled a curse against your son and killed him. (1313–1324)

THESEUS: My lady, let me die!

ARTEMIS: You have done terrible things, but nevertheless it is still possible, even for you, to find pardon for your actions. For it was Aphrodite who wished that these things should come about to satisfy her anger. There is a law for the gods as follows: no one of us wishes to thwart the will of another, but we always stand aside. (1325–1330)

For understand me clearly—If I were not in fear of Zeus' retaliation, I would never have sunk to such a depth of shame as to allow the death of the man dearest to me of all mortals. Ignorance, first of all, acquits you of evil; and besides, your wife by dying prevented your testing the truth of her accusations and so she made you believe her. As it is, these misfortunes have burst upon you most of all; but I too feel pain. The gods have no joy in the deaths of the good and reverent, but those who are wicked we destroy, children, house and all. (1331–1341)



Audio

(Hippolytus is brought in by servants.)

CHORUS: Here comes the poor fellow, his young flesh mutilated, his fair hair befouled. Oh, the suffering of this house. What grief—not once but now a second time—has been brought down upon it by the gods! (1342–1346)

HIPPOLYTUS: Ah, what pain. I, unfortunate, destroyed by the unjust curse of an unjust father. Alas, wretched, I am done for, woe is me. Pains shoot through my head, spasms dart around my brain. Stop, servants, let me rest my exhausted body. Oh, what pain! O hateful chariot, drawn by horses fed by my own hand. You have destroyed me, you have killed me. Ah what agony! Servants, by the gods, place your hands lightly on my lacerated flesh. Who stands at my right side? Lift me gently; take me along carefully, me the ill-fated one, cursed by my father's wrongdoing. Zeus, Zeus, do you see what is happening? Here I am, a holy and god-revering man, one who surpassed all others in virtue going to my inevitable death. My life is utterly destroyed, and I have performed my labors of piety on behalf of mortals, all for nothing. (1347–1369) 10

Ah, ah, the pain, the pain which now overwhelms me. Let go of me in my misery and may death come as my healer. Kill me, destroy me and my pain, doomed as I am. I long for the thrust of a two-edged sword to end my life and bring peaceful rest. Oh, unfortunate curse of my father. Some bloodstained evil, inherited from my ancestors long ago, rises up and does not stay dormant but has come against me. Why, oh why, when I am guilty of no evil myself? Woe is me, alas! What am I to say? How will I turn my life of pain into painlessness? If only the inevitable fate of death would transport me, one doomed to suffer so, into the night of Hades' realm. (1370–1388) 20

ARTEMIS: O poor, wretched fellow, how great is the yoke of your misfortune! The nobility of your nature has destroyed you.

HIPPOLYTUS: Ah, what a breath of divine fragrance! Even amidst my misfortunes, I feel your presence, and the pain in my body is lifted. The goddess Artemis is present in this place.

ARTEMIS: Gallant sufferer, yes, she is most dear to you of all the gods.

HIPPOLYTUS: Do you see me, my Lady, how wretched I am? (1395) 30

ARTEMIS: I see your misery but it is not right for my eyes to shed a tear.

HIPPOLYTUS: Your huntsman and your servant is no more.

ARTEMIS: No, indeed, but you die most dear to me.

HIPPOLYTUS: No longer the keeper of your horses or the attendant of your statues.

ARTEMIS: Because the evil-schemer Cypris planned it so. (1400)

HIPPOLYTUS: Alas, I understand what goddess has destroyed me.

ARTEMIS: She resented your slights to her honor and hated you for being chaste.

HIPPOLYTUS: This one goddess has destroyed the three of us, I realize now. 40

ARTEMIS: Your father and you, and his wife, the third.

HIPPOLYTUS: And so I bemoan the misfortunes of my father as well as my own. (1405)

ARTEMIS: He was deceived by the designs of a god.

HIPPOLYTUS: Oh, how unhappy you must be, father, because of your great misfortune!

THESEUS: I am done for, my son, and for me there remains no joy in life.

HIPPOLYTUS: I pity you more than I pity myself for mistaken wrongdoing.

- THESEUS: If only I could die, my son, instead of you. (1410)
- HIPPOLYTUS: How bitter the gifts of your father, Poseidon! 50
- THESEUS: That curse should never have come to my lips.
- HIPPOLYTUS: Why not? You would have killed me anyway, you were in such a state of anger.
- THESEUS: Because the gods had taken away my good sense.
- HIPPOLYTUS: Oh, if only mortals could send a curse upon the gods! (1415)
- ARTEMIS: No need of a curse. Even though you are in the dark depths of the earth, the rage that has been leveled against your very being through the zealous will of the goddess Cypris will not go unavenged, so that your piety and goodness of heart may be rewarded. For I will punish a lover of hers, the one mortal who is especially the dearest, by this unfailing bow of mine. To you, poor sufferer, I will bestow the greatest of honors in the city of Troezen in recompense for these evil torments of yours. Unmarried girls, before their marriage, will cut off their hair in dedication to you, the one who will reap the rich harvest of their mourning and tears through the span of the ages. The songs of maidens inspired by the Muses will keep your memory alive forever, and Phaedra's passion for you will not be left unsung and become forgotten. (1416–1480) 60
- You, son of revered Aegeus, take your son in your arms and embrace him; for you destroyed him unwittingly, and it is to be expected for human beings to err, when the gods so ordain. I advise you, Hippolytus, not to hate your father. You have been destroyed by the destiny that is yours. (1431–1436) 70
- Farewell. It is not right for me to look upon the dead or to defile my sight with the last gasps of the dying; and I see that you are now near that terrible state. (1437–1439)
- HIPPOLYTUS: Go as I bid you farewell, blessed virgin; how easily you leave behind our long relationship. Yet I put an end to my conflict with my father, since you so desire. For, in the past, indeed, I was persuaded by your words.
- Ah, darkness is now closing over my eyes. Take hold of me, father, and lay out my body in death. (1440–1445) 80
- THESEUS: Alas, my son, what terrible thing are you doing to me, one so ill-fated?
- HIPPOLYTUS: I am done for; indeed, I see the gates of the Underworld.
- THESEUS: And will you leave me with my hands defiled?
- HIPPOLYTUS: No, not at all, since I acquit you of this murder.
- THESEUS: What are you saying? Do you free me from blood-guilt? (1450)
- HIPPOLYTUS: I invoke Artemis with her indomitable bow as my witness.
- THESEUS: O dearest son, what nobility you show toward your father!
- HIPPOLYTUS: Farewell to you, father, I wish you much happiness.
- THESEUS: Alas for me to lose a son of such piety and goodness!
- HIPPOLYTUS: Pray that your true-born sons may be like me. (1455) 90
- THESEUS: Do not forsake me now, my son, but hold on courageously.
- HIPPOLYTUS: I can hold on to life no longer. It is over, father. Cover my face—quickly.
- THESEUS: O renowned land of Erechtheus and Pallas, what a man you have lost. I, in my wretchedness, will remember all too well, Cypris, the evils you have wrought. (1459–1461)
- CHORUS: This unexpected sorrow has come for all the citizens to share. There will be a flood of many tears. For lamentable stories about those who are great can inspire a more intense grief. (1462–1466)

Although Artemis declares her love for Hippolytus, she remains cool and aloof, as antiseptic in some respects as her fanatical follower. The rites she predicts in honor of Hippolytus were celebrated in Troezen, and the beloved of Cypris whom she will kill has been specifically identified as Adonis (who in some versions of his death is killed by Artemis' arrows).

Hippolytus' farewell to Artemis is a beautiful example of Euripides' succinct and profound irony. The sad ambiguity of Hippolytus' words may be highlighted by a different but not unfaithful translation with interpretation: "You, go without any pain, fortunate lady! [I am in pain, unfortunate, and dying.] How readily (or lightly) you abandon my deep devotion. I will become reconciled to my father since you want me to. I will obey you now, as I have done in the past [through the ingrained conviction of a religious habit, which not even my disappointment in your present behavior can dispel. My worship and obedience end like this]."

In their final reconciliation, the theme of Theseus' recognition of the true nobility of his bastard son, and Hippolytus' hope for Theseus that his true-born sons by Phaedra may turn out as worthy, underlines the psychological importance of this basic motif of legitimacy in the play.

Later Adaptations of the Legend

There have been many subsequent dramatic versions of the legend. The treatment by the Roman Seneca (A.D. 65) in his *Phaedra* is well worth studying for its own dramatic merit and as a contrast to Euripides' extant version. There are many differences, both in plot and in characterization, and he explores the psychological tensions of the myth without the goddesses Aphrodite or Artemis appearing as actual figures in the play. Seneca has Phaedra herself (not her Nurse) confront Hippolytus with her lust as she attempts to seduce him. Euripides wrote two dramas about Hippolytus, and Seneca, in this scene, was probably inspired by the earlier version; this first *Hippolytus* of Euripides was not a success and no longer survives. The second version (named *Hippolytos Stephanephoros* to distinguish it from the first), which Euripides produced in 428, is the one that we know today.

Other later plays on the theme are Jean Racine's *Phèdre* (1677); Eugene O'Neill's *Desire under the Elms* (1924), also influenced by *Medea*; and Robinson Jeffers' *The Cretan Woman* (1954). The manipulation of the character of Hippolytus is illuminating. For example, Racine, by giving Hippolytus a girlfriend in his version, drastically changes the configuration of the Euripidean archetype. Jeffers is closer to Euripides by keeping Hippolytus' abhorrence of sex; but when he introduces a companion for Hippolytus who is "slender and rather effeminate," he suggests another shifting of the archetype of the holy man. At any rate, once Hippolytus' sexual orientation is made too explicit, the mystery of his psyche is diminished. Euripides gets everything right, a judgment made with due respect for the masterpieces that he has inspired. The twentieth-century novel *The Bull from the Sea*, by Mary Renault, is yet another rewarding reinterpretation of the myth. The movie adaptation, *Phaedra* (see Chapter 28 on the companion website), is of some interest.

The attempted seduction of a holy man and its dire consequences represent familiar motifs in literature (in the Bible, for example, see the stories of Joseph and Potiphar's wife and of John the Baptist and Salome).

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Primary Sources

Sources in the Chapter

Euripides	<i>Hippolytus</i> (selections)
Homeric Hymn 9	<i>To Artemis</i>
Homeric Hymn 27	<i>To Artemis</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 2.409–507; 3.138–255

Additional Sources

Callimachus	<i>To Artemis</i> (Hymn 3)
Ovid	<i>Heroides</i> 4: Phaedra to Hippolytus
Seneca	<i>Phaedra</i>
Theocritus	<i>Idyll</i> 2

Notes

1. Sometimes the place of birth is called Ortygia (the name means “quail island”), which cannot be identified with certainty. In some accounts, it is clearly not merely another name for Delos; in others, it is.
2. Niobe was the wife of Amphion, ruling by his side in the royal palace of Cadmus. As the daughter of Tantalus and the granddaughter of Atlas, her lineage was much more splendid than that of Leto, the daughter of an obscure Titan, Coeus.
3. A rock on Mt. Sipylus in Asia Minor was identified in antiquity as the figure of Niobe.
4. Actaeon was the son of Aristaeus and Autonoë.
5. The nymphs’ names, which are omitted in the translation, are Greek words suggestive of cool, crystal-clear water.
6. A stag was commonly believed to live nine times as long as a man.
7. Still Ovid goes on to give thirty-one more names, which are omitted in the translation.
8. Orion sometimes appears as the son of Earth; in other accounts, his father is Poseidon.
9. Or Orion was run through by Artemis’ arrows. Orion also attempted to rape Opis, a follower of Artemis, if indeed she is not the goddess herself.
10. Several of the nymphs associated with her (e.g., Callisto and Opis) were probably once goddesses in their own right and may actually represent various manifestations of Artemis’ own complex nature. One of them, Britomartis, is closely linked to Crete, and perhaps was once a traditional mother-goddess.
11. See John M. Camp, *The Archaeology of Athens* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2001); Ken Dowden, *Death and the Maiden: Girls’ Initiation Rites in Greek Mythology* (New York: Routledge, 1989), pp. 20–47; and Christopher Faraone, “Playing the Bear and the Fawn for Artemis: Female Initiation or Substitute Sacrifice?” in *Initiation in*

Ancient Greek Rituals and Narratives: New Critical Perspectives, eds. David B. Dodd and Christopher A. Faraone (New York: Routledge, 2003), pp. 43–68.

12. Cf. Michael P. Carroll, *The Cult of the Virgin Mary: Psychological Origins* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1986). Carroll ignores the aspects of Artemis as a mother figure when he states (p. 8): “there is little or no basis in Graeco-Roman mythology for portraying either [Artemis or Athena] as a mother figure.” He has, however, very perceptive analogies to make with the worship of Cybele (pp. 90–112).
13. Hecate’s mother, Asterie, is Leto’s sister; her father is Perses.
14. For more on the legend of Hippolytus and his cult-sites, see pp. 597 and 681.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to
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